



PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

CARING FOR GROWTH

Healthcare Sector

- **₹16.4 lakh crore:** Projected market size by 2025
- **2.1% of GDP:** The government's health expenditure for 2024
- **700,000+:** The total number of healthcare facilities in India
- **1.8 million+:** Total number of hospital beds in the country, with the private sector managing about 70%
- **₹86,175 crore:** The estimated expenditure of the Department of Health and Family Welfare in 2023-24, according to the government

Pharmaceutical Sector

- **Size:** According to the Economic Survey 2023, the Indian pharmaceutical industry is experiencing rapid growth, and is projected to reach \$450 billion (₹37,350 crore) by 2047
- **Key Focus Areas:** Digital health, personalised medicine, AI and robotics, innovative therapies for non-communicable diseases (NCDs), and combination therapies
- **Role in Global Market:** India's reputation as a leading pharma manufacturing hub is expected to grow, with an emphasis on sustainability and next-generation vaccines and therapies

Diagnostics Sector

- **Size:** The sector is estimated to grow to ₹2,324 crore by 2025
- **Growth Areas:** Point-of-care testing, advancements in genomics and proteomics, integration of digital diagnostics, and increase in diagnostic tests per sample
- **Future Role:** India is expected to become a major hub for specialised medical testing, driven by advancements in genomics, microbiology, and molecular diagnostics

But Shah notes that diagnostics will require insurance coverage to make them affordable. "Including diagnostic services in medical insurance coverage will ensure that healthcare costs are no longer predominantly out-of-pocket expenses," Shah says.

Shah says public-private collaborations will also be essential in expanding the diagnostics infrastructure.

Veterans such as Dr Harsh Mahajan, Founder and Chairman of Mahajan Imaging & Labs, say PPPs are the need of the hour. "Diagnostics are a very important part of preventive, predictive, and precision medicine, and PPP will take high-quality diagnostics to all parts of the country," says Mahajan, who also chairs the Health Services Committee of the Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce & Industry.

"The current emphasis on the lowest cost has to give way to the realisation amongst the public payer that quality comes at a cost. If financially viable models are developed, the private sector will join the government in providing universal healthcare," he says.

Sometimes, the reaction to a crisis leads to a breakthrough. Covid-19 spurred a mammoth vaccination drive. Although India has had an immunisation programme for decades covering 12 diseases, it never recorded who was vaccinated and who was not.

In 2021, the government could create the Co-WIN platform by tapping into the digital world of Aadhaar's biometric identification number, smartphones, and the QR code boom created by the pandemic. Now, it plans to use the platform to record all vaccinations. And the world wants Co-WIN. **BT**

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